of the breakaway East Pakistan (today Bangladesh), infuriating the U.S. President Richard Nixon, who personally had urged her, just weeks before, to remain neutral.[187] Following Mrs. Gandhi's assassination by Sikh nationalists in 1984, she was succeeded as prime minister by her son, Rajiv Gandhi, who was himself assassinated in 1989 in protest over the end of India's intervention in neighboring Sri Lanka's civil war.

By the 1990s, Indian national politics struggled to move beyond the decades of dynastic democracy, centered on the Nehru–(Indira) Gandhi family. Each of the two loose coalitions that has since alternated in control of the central government has shared a large area of agreement in terms of foreign policy priorities. The dominant Western industrial democracies are still often conceptualized (and resented) within Indian elite circles as the "former colonial powers." Indian politicians and opinion leaders across the political spectrum promote nonintervention and a respect for Westphalian sovereignty (except when Indian leaders decide to intervene in their weaker neighbors to ensure "stability"). The center-right, assertively nationalist New Democratic Alliance (NDA), led by the Hindu nationalist Bharatia Janata Party (BJP), held national power from 1996 through 2004. The BJP is the party of Prime Minister Narendra Modi (2014–). Deeply suspicious of neighboring Pakistan, NDA rhetoric has been somewhat friendlier to the United States and to private business, and the country receives substantial financial and moral support from the Indian expatriate community, especially in North America.

The other contemporary alliance is the left-leaning, rhetorically socialist United Progressive Alliance (UPA), led by the Congress Party (Indian National Congress, INC), which was the affiliation of Prime Minister Manmohan Singh (2004–2014). Although the left normally is more critical of the United States, it was the government of the center-left UPA leader Singh that negotiated the historic 2005 nuclear deal with U.S. President George W. Bush, in which the United States agreed to exempt India from further Western sanctions due to its refusal to join the Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty, which India claimed reinforced existing and unfair global inequality. Reversing its previous stance, the United States acknowledged that "India was a nuclear power" and agreed to bilateral cooperation in civilian nuclear energy.[188] Despite these warming relations with the West, Indian policymakers and elites strongly opposed U.S. and Western interventions in support of political regime change, as in Iraq in